

TUSKER ALERT
Elephant task force officials on duty in Sakleshpur

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to alert civilians. In many villages, LED boards flash elephants' locations. Most notable though are the SMS alerts sent to about 5,000 subscribers every day. Abdul Hamid, who runs a small general store, is one of the subscribers. Not taking any chances, he checks the alerts daily—a young planter was killed in an encounter just 4 km away in November last year.

The SMS alerts were started to make day-to-day movement safer for civilians, as most deaths in the past took place either in the early morning or around dusk, when the victims, usually unaware of the presence of elephants around, were either going to the farms or returning home, says M. Ananda Kumar, a senior scientist at the Nature Conservation Foundation (NCF), a Mysuru-based wildlife research organisation. So, a round-the-clock information-gathering system involving residents and the elephant task force (ETF) was put in place. Members of NCF fan out every morning tracking elephant movements, while ETF teams patrol estates where coffee picking is on. "The target [for reducing deaths] is zero," says Kumar.

PUSH AND PULL

What used to be a transient migration pattern earlier, from Kodagu in the south to Hassan, now involves resident herds, says K.N. Basavaraja, the deputy conservator of forests, Hassan division. "If you drive them away from one place, they go to another, and if you drive them away from there, they come back here," says K.N. Subramanya, president of the Hassan District Planters Association.

Noted ecologist Prof R. Sukumar, who chaired the expert panel to look at the Hassan-Kodagu conflict zone back in 2012, attributes this to a complex push-and-pull pattern that he says is visible in various parts of the country. "Today, the idea of what is a natural habitat for elephants is questionable. They can pretty much thrive anywhere," he says. While agricultural productivity outside forest areas has improved because of irrigation—thereby attracting elephants to food sources—factors such as habitat loss, fragmentation and degradation are also at play. Framing this backdrop is the recent expansion of the invasive weed species *Lantana Camara* across the forests of southern India. Lantana was introduced to India as an ornamental flowering plant in the early 19th century. "But the big expansion took place around 2005," says Sukumar, who was involved in designing the Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, which has the largest population of wild elephants in India. A combination of prolonged drought in the early noughties followed by fires led to the spread of Lantana—while grasses on the forest slopes got suppressed, the woody Lantana thrived. "Grasses are a significant component of elephants' diet...so, in a sense, now they are seeking that in the form of paddy and millets growing outside forest areas. That's what I call the push factor."

OVER THE YEARS, FORESTERS HAVE TRIED VARIOUS METHODS TO KEEP ELEPHANTS CONFINED TO FORESTS, BUT NONE OF THEM HAS PROVED TO BE TENABLE IN THE LONG TERM

Conservationists like Kumar say that a balancing act is needed, for elephant herds will continue to stray out of forests given that they are a free-ranging species. On the other hand, planters feel that relocating them is the only way forward. That in itself is a mammoth task, carried out only periodically—between 2000 and 2022, as many as 74 wild elephants were captured in Hassan and rehabilitated. For now, the warning systems are the only assurance for the people of Hassan. Surveillance is being stepped up. So far, matriarchs of three herds have been radio-collared. However, it's the lone tuskers—either sub-adults or males edged out by other dominant male elephants of the herds—that are posing problems, says Basavaraja. Hence, the forest department plans to radio-collar nine more elephants soon. An additional 11 km of rail barricades along the Hassan-Kodagu crossover points are also in the works.

Beyond this two-pronged strategy, there currently seems to be no lasting solution to this elephantine problem. Back at Kirehalli, Beetamma has left the coffee estate with her herd, but a smaller group led by a matriarch named Bhuvaneshwari has moved in. For Hassan, this is now a tug-of-war with nature itself. ■